

The Origins of TERROR

How the tribal lands of Pakistan have become the epicentre of the jihad industry

By Manvendra Singh



THE AL QAEDA CONNECTION: THE TALIBAN AND TERROR IN PAKISTAN'S TRIBAL AREAS
by IMTIAZ GUL
Penguin
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 308

The Godzilla, born out of the anti-Soviet jihad... had meanwhile multiplied and thrown up scores... now threatening the... country that had midwived (sic) their creation... These human bombs, originally designed and nurtured to destroy enemies of Islam and Pakistan... started exploding... inside their own country". This just about captures the essence of what *The Al Qaeda Connection* seeks to explain and expose in the murky world of terror and intrigue. Jihad Inc does not run on belief alone.

Joining the burgeoning ranks that fill bookshelves devoted to Afghanistan, Pakistan and terror, *The Al Qaeda Connection* is aimed at specifically analysing the phenomenon from its epicentre, the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) that nestle along the Durand Line. Most books have analysed groups, states, or even individuals, but this one looks at the experience from the once romanticised but traumatised FATA. Travel accounts from the early 19th century till almost the next 100 years regarded this mountainous region with a certain awe and fascination for its inhabitants. Wild in spirit and rebellion while disciplined in devotion to their hereditary regulations, the various Pashtoon tribes inspired unmitigated Orientalist overkill. It was an industry stimulated by

wonderment and trepidation.

The new industry is driven by terror that has reached every home, and every heart, globally. FATA is today the headquarters of global terror. And into this rocky terrain Imtiaz Gul enters with ample experience as an international reporter and researcher. From the launching grounds of the anti-Soviet enterprise, FATA has become the sanctuary of terror across the seven seas. The author seeks answers to this very rapid degeneration.

Like one of the security agents he quotes, "I am probably as confused as you are... It is murky and obscure." The reader is left with a similar feeling at the end of this anecdote-packed book. What is known is that upon retreating from the American-led Operation Enduring Freedom, the entire Al Qaeda leadership vanished in the borderlands of the Durand Line. There was once a dispute over whether they were in Afghanistan or had crossed the imaginary line into Pakistan. But as the book explains, it really doesn't matter since the border existed only in atlases and maps in war rooms. The tribes living here have crossed the craggy mountain passes with impunity. And with the same ease came the Al Qaeda leadership.

What had been attempted by Pakistan was a recipe of unimaginable proportions. It began even before the Soviet troops landed at Bagram airbase in late 1979. Pakistan had built up a network of Islamist groups through state patronage, and once the Soviets walked into Afghanistan, all the investment began to pay. Freedom became the mantra as Washington, Riyadh and Beijing began to roll out dollars for investing in Jihad Inc. Finally, the green flag would be raised in Kashmir. Or so thought the ISI. But not everything goes according to the plot, and in between came Osama, Mullah Omar (by chance, claims the author), and all the fury that followed.

The chickens have come home to roost; so says the author in many different words, and through various intriguing anecdotes. All the conspiracies associated with the Orient are in this book, but nothing as damning as a Pakistani diplomat's remark, "most Pakistanis were seen as untrustworthy partners who could betray the Taliban whenever the crunch came". The plot is never clear. ■

